GAME DESIGN DOCUMENT

CO-OP SEAFARING ADVENTURE · PRE-PRODUCTION

# Sea of Sheep

Crew a small ship with your friends and sail from home harbor across an escalating open sea. Reach Sanctuary together — and you win.

| VERSION | DATE | PLAYERS | ENGINE |
| --- | --- | --- | --- |
| 0.1 — Vision | June 2026 | 1–4 co-op | Unity (PC) |

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# 01 High concept

**Sea of Sheep** is a 1–4 player, third-person co-op seafaring adventure. You and your friends crew a single small ship and sail from a home harbor across a bounded stretch of open sea that grows more dangerous the further you go. Each voyage is one self-contained run of roughly 30–60 minutes. Cross the final stretch, drop anchor at **Sanctuary** — the fabled safe-haven island at the edge of the map — and the voyage is won.

The fantasy is the camaraderie of crewing a ship: one friend at the wheel, one trimming the sails, one on the cannons, one bailing water and patching holes — all pulling toward a finish line you can literally see on the horizon. It takes the joyful chaos of a shared ship and gives it something Sea of Thieves deliberately withholds: **a clear destination and an ending.**

**THE CORE DIFFERENCE**

Sea of Thieves is a vast, persistent, win-less sandbox. Sea of Sheep is **finite, directed, and winnable** — one ship, one crew, one bounded sea, one short session, one shared finish line. Smaller scale by design, built for a single friend group per run rather than a shared open world.

## 02 Design pillars

Every feature is measured against these four. If it doesn't serve a pillar, it's cut.

**PILLAR 01**

### One ship, one finish line

A shared goal on the horizon. The voyage is the content; everything on board serves reaching Sanctuary together.

**PILLAR 02**

### Hands always full

There is always a job. Roles are fluid, never assigned — the ship constantly demands that someone step up. Teamwork is the engine.

**PILLAR 03**

### The sea escalates

Calm start, dangerous middle, dramatic finish. Difficulty curves with distance, so the journey has a built-in dramatic arc.

**PILLAR 04**

### Short voyages, tall stories

30–60 minute runs that manufacture memorable chaos and are endlessly re-runnable. You finish a voyage with a story to retell.

## 03 Game overview

| 1–4 | 30–60 | 4 | 1 |
|---|---|---|---|
| Players, drop-in co-op | Minutes per voyage | Escalating sea zones | Shared finish line |

| | |
|---|---|
| Genre | Co-op seafaring adventure — sail, survive, arrive |
| Perspective | Third-person (over-the-shoulder on foot; station cameras at wheel & cannons) |
| Players | 1–4 online co-op, drop-in / drop-out. Solo-playable with sailing assists |
| Session | One voyage = one run, ~30–60 min. Roguelike-lite: fresh ship each voyage |
| Structure | Home Harbor → 4 escalating zones → Sanctuary. Procedurally assembled from authored chunks |
| Win condition | The surviving crew reaches Sanctuary and steps ashore |
| Mode | PvE co-op. Optional rival "ghost ship" pressure — no open-world PvP griefing |
| Platform | PC / Steam first. Controller + KBM. Console-friendly scope |

## 04 The voyage — world structure

A voyage is a sea-lane: a sequence of authored zones that escalate from calm to climactic. Island placement, weather, and encounters are randomized within each zone, so every voyage differs while the dramatic curve stays fixed.

PROLOGUE

**Home Harbor**

Provision, pick a loadout, learn the ropes. Safe.

ZONE 01

**The Calm Shallows**

Gentle intro seas. Easy loot islands, the wind teaches you to sail.

ZONE 02

**The Reaches**

Open water. Reefs, shifting weather, first rival sloops & sea life.

ZONE 03

**The Stormwall**

Storms, towering waves, low visibility. A serpent stalks the deep.

FINALE

**Sanctuary**

The beacon on the horizon. Make the final approach and arrive.

### BETWEEN ZONES — SAFE HAVENS

Each zone ends at a calm **waystation island**: repair the ship, resupply, and spend salvage with the Quartermaster on upgrades before committing to the next, more dangerous leg. The waystation is the breather and the decision point — where do you spend, and which route do you risk next?

### BRANCHING ROUTES

Within a zone the crew chooses lanes at the navigation table: the **safe-but-long** path hugs the islands; the **fast-but-risky** path cuts through open hazard for time and richer salvage. Route choice is the strategic spine that keeps repeat voyages fresh.

## 05 Core gameplay loop

Moment to moment, the crew cycles through five activities. None has a dedicated owner — players flow between them as the sea demands.

**1 — Sail**
Steer, trim sails, read the wind, hold a heading.

**2 — Maintain**
Patch breaches, bail water, manage wood & supplies.

**3 — Fight**
Crew the cannons, repel boarders, face sea monsters.

**4 — Explore**
Anchor at islands, loot supplies, salvage & treasure.

**5 — Decide**
Pick the route, spend salvage, push the next zone.

**MACRO LOOP**

Cross a zone → reach a waystation → repair, resupply & upgrade → choose the next route → push into deeper, more dangerous water. Repeat until the Sanctuary beacon rises on the horizon.

## 06 The ship & crew stations

A single small ship sized for a crew of four — readable from bow to stern, no station more than a few seconds' run away. Stations are interaction points, never locked roles.

**Helm**
Steer the ship. Best view forward, worst view of damage below.

**Sails**
Raise, lower & angle the sails. Speed lives in the wind.

**Cannons**
Port & starboard guns. Aim, load shot type, fire.

**Navigation**
Map table, compass & spyglass. Plot the route, spot the beacon.

**Damage control**
Plank breaches, bail flooding, work the pump. Stop the sinking.

**Anchor & capstan**
Drop for hard turns & docking, raise to set off again.

### SOLO & SMALL CREWS

With fewer than four players the ship eases off: auto-trim assists keep the sails sane, enemy density scales down, and breaches arrive slower. The "everyone has a job" tension stays — it just never becomes unfair.

# 07 Mechanics in detail

## Sailing & the wind

Speed is a function of **sail trim × wind alignment × hull condition − cargo weight**. Sailing directly downwind is fast; sailing into it means tacking in a zig-zag. Wind shifts over the voyage, so the helm and sails are in constant conversation. This is the skill floor the whole game rests on — easy to push off, deep to master.

## Navigation

By default there is **no hand-holding waypoint line**. The crew navigates with a physical map table, a compass, landmarks, and — in the final zone — Sanctuary's beacon glowing on the horizon. A tunable *assist mode* adds a soft heading marker for casual groups.

- **Map table** — shared, diegetic; anyone can plot the route and place markers others see.
- **Compass & spyglass** — hold a heading in fog; scout islands and rival ships at distance.
- **The beacon** — only lit in the final zone, so the ending always feels earned, not given.

## Ship combat

Third-person cannon aiming with manual reload and three shot types: **round shot** (hull), **chain shot** (sails & rigging — slow a runner), and **grape** (clear boarders on deck). Enemies can grapple aboard; repel them with light cutlass melee. Melee exists to create panic on deck, not to be a fighting game — the ship is always the real weapon.

## Survival & maintenance

**HULL INTEGRITY**
Cannon fire, reefs & storms open breaches. Unpatched holes let water in.

**WATER LEVEL**
Flooding rises if breaches outpace bailing. Full hold = the ship sinks.

**SUPPLIES**
Wood for repairs, cannonballs, and food/morale. Run dry and the voyage bites.

## Salvage & treasure

Islands and wrecks yield **supplies** (immediate use) and **salvage** (the run currency). Chests and map fragments reward exploration; salvage is spent at waystation Quartermasters on ship upgrades and consumables. Risk-heavy routes pay richer salvage — the economy quietly pushes the crew toward danger.

# 08 Progression & upgrades

Two layers — one inside the voyage, one across voyages. Neither is allowed to trivialize the sea; skill stays central.

Within a run

### Ship upgrades

Spend salvage at waystations on the hull (more breach tolerance), sails (top speed), cannons (reload & punch), and hold capacity (more supplies). Resets every voyage — each run is its own arc.

Across runs

### Meta unlocks

Cosmetics (ship paint, sails, figureheads, crew outfits), alternate starting loadouts, harder sea-lanes & difficulty tiers, and a Captain's Log of tall-tale achievements. Variety and bragging rights — not raw power.

# 09 Win & loss — the ending

## Winning

The voyage is won when the **surviving crew reaches Sanctuary and steps ashore.** Arrival triggers a cinematic landfall and a **Voyage Summary** — loot hauled, monsters faced, breaches patched, closest call. Because the beacon only lights in the final zone, the finish always lands as a payoff, never a foregone conclusion.

**YOU ARRIVE TOGETHER, OR NOT AT ALL**

Sanctuary is a shared win — the ship makes landfall as a crew. A player who falls behind or goes down gets a grace window to rejoin so one person's bad luck never cheats the group out of the ending.

## Losing & recovery

- **Downed players** can be revived by a crewmate within a short window.

- **Death** respawns you back aboard after a brief delay — as long as the ship still floats.
- **Voyage over** only when the ship *sinks* and no crew can recover it. The crew washes back to Home Harbor with whatever meta progress they earned.

Failure is real but forgiving — tuned for a friend group laughing through a near-sink, not for punishing a single mistake.

## 10 Threats & encounters

Danger ramps with distance. Each threat type is introduced gently, then layered on top of the others as the sea escalates.

### RIVAL SLOOPS

NPC raider ships that chase, fire, and try to board. Outsail or outgun them — first seen in The Reaches.

### REEFS & ROCKS

Static hazards that punish bad navigation. Hidden in fog and shallows; tear hull breaches on impact.

### STORMS

Towering waves, lightning, and near-zero visibility in The Stormwall. Pure crew-coordination crucible.

### THE SERPENT

The signature sea monster — a coiling deep-sea threat that strikes the hull and demands cannon focus-fire.

Scope target for the first release: ~5 enemy/hazard types and **one** fully-realized sea monster. Depth over breadth.

## 11 Co-op & multiplayer

- **Drop-in / drop-out** 1–4 players over Steam relay; one host is authoritative for ship state.
- **Scales with crew** — enemy density, breach rate, and station load adjust to player count.
- **Communication tools** — proximity voice, a shared map table, quick pings, and emotes.
- **No open-world griefing** — this is a friend-group game. The only rival pressure is an optional AI/ghost ship, never another real crew invading your voyage.

### THE SOCIAL ENGINE

Friction is the fun: too many jobs for too few hands creates the shouting, the scramble, and the stories. The design protects that tension and removes everything that turns friends against each other.

# 12 Art direction & audio

Stylized, warm, lightly painterly — friendly rather than gritty, with bold readable silhouettes so the deck reads instantly in chaos. The sea and sky carry the mood, and each zone shifts the palette to reinforce the escalation.




The blue→purple→orange brand gradient maps naturally onto the voyage's emotional arc — the cool open sea giving way to the warm dawn light of Sanctuary at journey's end. It's the through-line tying every surface together.

## Audio

- **Dynamic sea ambience** — wind, hull creak, and wave intensity track the zone and weather.
- **Adaptive score** — drifts under calm sailing, surges in storms and combat, blooms into a triumphant theme on the Sanctuary approach.
- **Player shanties** — pick up a concertina or drum; crewmates can join in for a synced, morale-boosting tune. The signature social toy.

# 13 UX, camera & controls

- **Camera** — third-person over-the-shoulder on foot; snaps to a station-relative view at the wheel and an aim cam on the cannons.
- **HUD** — minimal & mostly diegetic: hull/water state, ammo, and context prompts. Sanctuary's marker only appears in the final zone.
- **Input** — full controller & KBM parity. One context-sensitive interact button drives every station.
- **Accessibility** — assist navigation, subtitles, colorblind-safe danger cues, adjustable difficulty & voyage length.

# 14 Technical design

| | |
|---|---|
| Engine | Unity (URP), C#. Stylized PBR; mid-range PC at 60 fps as the target |
| Networking | Host-authoritative co-op over Steam relay (Netcode for GameObjects or a proven mid-weight stack). Host migration is a stretch goal |
| Key tech risk | Buoyancy & water-sim synced across the network — the single hardest system; prototype it first |
| Content gen | Procedural sea-lane assembly from hand-authored zone chunks + randomized island/weather/encounter placement |
| MVP content | 1 ship class · 4 zones · ~6 island types · ~5 threat types · 1 sea monster |

# 15 Scope & roadmap

MILESTONE 1

**Prototype**

Sailing + networked water + one zone in local co-op. Proves the core feel and the hardest tech risk before anything else is built. Goal: "is crewing a ship together fun?"

MILESTONE 2

**Vertical slice**

A complete voyage end to end — Harbor → 2 zones → Sanctuary — with ship combat, the upgrade economy, and 2-player online co-op. Goal: one winnable run that feels like the real game.

MILESTONE 3

**Production**

All 4 zones, the full station set, the sea monster, meta cosmetics, and 4-player co-op. Goal: full content breadth.

MILESTONE 4

**Beta & polish**

Balancing across solo→4p, host migration, accessibility, performance, and a Steam release build. Goal: shippable.

# 16 Risks & open questions

### KNOWN RISKS

- Networked water/buoyancy sync is genuinely hard — de-risk in Milestone 1.
- Balancing the same voyage for 1 vs 4 players without dumbing it down.
- Keeping a single finish line fresh across many runs (procedural + meta variety must carry it).

### OPEN FOR THE TEAM

- Hard crew cap — lock at 4, or allow up to 6?
- Include the optional rival ghost ship, or keep it pure PvE?
- Ideal voyage length tuning — 30, 45, or 60 minutes as default?
- Mid-voyage checkpoints, or strict one-run-per-voyage?

This is a v0.1 vision document — directional, not final. The unanswered intake questions are folded into "Open for the team" above; once decided, the affected sections get locked and versioned.